

Hand Arthritis Exercises – Complete UK Guide

Step-by-step hand exercises for arthritis recommended by UK physiotherapists. Improve grip strength, flexibility, and reduce stiffness with these gentle exercises.

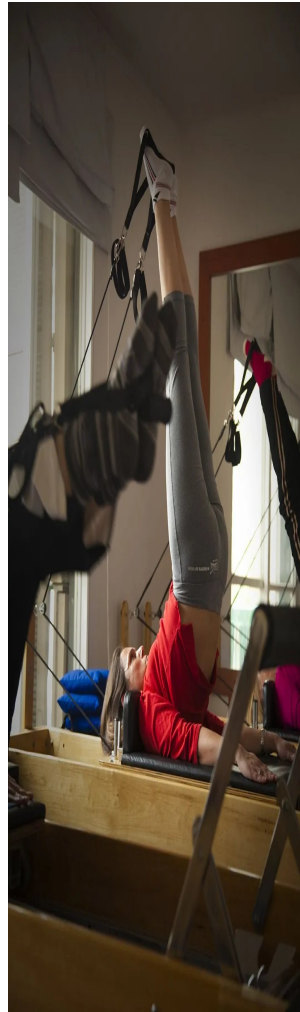
By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Hand arthritis can make even simple tasks difficult — from opening jars to buttoning a shirt. Regular hand exercises, recommended by UK physiotherapists and occupational therapists, can help maintain grip strength, improve flexibility, and reduce pain.

When to Exercise

- Best done after a warm bath or shower when joints are loosened
 - Start gently — a little discomfort is OK, sharp pain is not
 - Aim for 2-3 times daily for best results
 - Avoid exercising hot, swollen joints (wait for the flare to settle)
-

10 Hand Exercises for Arthritis



Openly licensed image via Openverse

1. Fist Making

Start with fingers straight. Slowly curl fingers into a fist, thumb on the outside. Hold 5 seconds. Straighten. Repeat 10 times.

2. Finger Spreading

Place hand flat on a table. Spread fingers as wide as possible. Hold 5 seconds. Relax. Repeat 10 times.

3. Finger Lifts

Place hand flat on table. Lift each finger individually, hold 2 seconds, lower. Repeat 5 times per finger.

4. Thumb Circles

Hold hand in a relaxed position. Move thumb in small circles, 10 clockwise, 10 anticlockwise.

5. Thumb-to-Finger Touch

Touch your thumb to each fingertip in turn, making an "O" shape. Repeat 5 full rounds.

6. Table Top Stretch

Place palm flat on table. Gently press each finger flat. Hold 10 seconds. This helps if fingers are curling.

7. Wrist Rotations

Hold forearm steady. Rotate wrist slowly in circles — 10 clockwise, 10 anticlockwise.

8. Prayer Stretch

Press palms together at chest level. Slowly lower hands while keeping palms pressed. Feel the stretch in wrists and fingers. Hold 15 seconds.

9. Stress Ball Squeeze

Gently squeeze a soft stress ball or rolled-up sock. Hold 5 seconds. Release. Repeat 10 times. Builds grip strength.

10. Rubber Band Extension

Place a rubber band around all five fingertips. Spread fingers against the resistance. Hold 3 seconds. Repeat 10 times. Strengthens finger extensors.

Aids and Adaptations

- Therapy putty — provides progressive resistance for hand strengthening
 - Paraffin wax bath — warming treatment before exercise (available at some physiotherapy departments)
 - Compression gloves — reduce swelling and provide warmth (available from pharmacies)
-

When to See a Professional



Openly licensed image via Openverse

Ask your GP for a referral to a hand therapist (specialist OT or physiotherapist) if:

- Pain is preventing you from doing daily tasks
- You need a custom splint
- Exercises aren't helping after 4-6 weeks
- You notice new deformities in your fingers or thumbs

Consistency is key — even 5 minutes of hand exercises twice daily can make a significant difference over time.

Hand Exercises for Osteoarthritis

For hand and thumb osteoarthritis, daily gentle range-of-motion and graded grip strengthening with a soft therapy putty is the gold-standard programme. Evidence shows 8–12 weeks of

consistent practice reduces pain and improves grip strength by 20–30%. See our osteoarthritis exercises guide and osteoarthritis treatment overview.

Hand Exercises for Rheumatoid Arthritis



Openly licensed image via Openverse

RA frequently affects the small joints of the hand. During flares, restrict to gentle range-of-motion and avoid grip-strengthening. Out of flare, the SARAH programme (Strengthening And stretching for Rheumatoid Arthritis of the Hand) is the most evidence-backed routine in the UK. Full pacing rules: rheumatoid arthritis exercises.

Gentle Hand Exercises for Severe Arthritis

For severe hand arthritis, focus on pain-free movement only: gentle finger bends, thumb opposition (touch each fingertip), warm-water soaks before exercise and short 5-minute sessions 3–4 times per day. Stop any movement that produces sharp pain.

Thumb (CMC) Arthritis Exercises

Base-of-thumb arthritis is one of the most common forms of hand OA. Key exercises: thumb opposition, thumb abduction with a rubber band, gentle "C" stretch and isometric pinch holds. A thumb splint during heavy tasks combined with this routine is the standard UK conservative treatment.

Exercises to Avoid With Hand Arthritis

Avoid heavy gripping with stiff stress balls, repeated forceful pinching, fast-paced finger exercises and any movement that produces sharp pain. Soft therapy putty (graded by resistance) is the safer alternative. For a personalised plan, find a hand therapist near you.

Hand Arthritis Exercise FAQ — People Also Ask

What are the best exercises for arthritic hands?

The best routine combines daily range-of-motion (finger bends, fist-to-fan, thumb opposition) with graded grip strengthening using soft therapy putty 3–4 times per week. The SARAH programme is the most evidence-backed UK routine for hand RA.

How often should I do hand exercises for arthritis?

Gentle range-of-motion daily (2–3 short sessions of 5 minutes), grip strengthening 3–4 times per week. Warm the hands first with a 5-minute warm-water soak.

Can hand exercises cure arthritis?

No, but consistent practice can reduce pain by 20–30%, improve grip strength and slow loss of function. Stopping the programme reverses the gains within weeks.

What hand exercises should I avoid with arthritis?

Avoid stiff stress balls, forceful gripping, fast repetitions and any movement causing sharp pain. Use soft graded therapy putty instead.

Are there gentle hand exercises for severe arthritis?

Yes — gentle finger bends, thumb-to-fingertip touches, wrist circles and warm-water exercises. Keep sessions to 5 minutes, 3–4 times daily.

How long until hand exercises reduce arthritis pain?

Most people notice reduced stiffness within 2 weeks, with meaningful pain and grip improvements at 8–12 weeks of consistent practice.

Related Hand & Arthritis Guides

- Osteoarthritis exercises — full programme
 - Osteoarthritis treatment options (UK)
 - Rheumatoid arthritis exercises
 - More hand exercises for osteoarthritis
 - Hand exercises for rheumatoid arthritis
 - Anti-inflammatory diet for arthritis
 - Find a hand therapist near you
-

Q&A

Question: What are the best exercises for arthritic hands?

Short answer: The best routine combines daily range-of-motion (finger bends, fist-to-fan, thumb opposition) with graded grip strengthening using soft therapy putty 3–4 times per week. The SARAH programme is the most evidence-backed UK routine for hand RA.

Question: How often should I do hand exercises for arthritis?

Short answer: Gentle range-of-motion daily (2–3 short sessions of 5 minutes), grip strengthening 3–4 times per week. Warm the hands first with a 5-minute warm-water soak.

Question: Can hand exercises cure arthritis?

Short answer: No, but consistent practice can reduce pain by 20–30%, improve grip strength and slow loss of function. Stopping the programme reverses the gains within weeks.

Question: What hand exercises should I avoid with arthritis?

Short answer: Avoid stiff stress balls, forceful gripping, fast repetitions and any movement causing sharp pain. Use soft graded therapy putty instead.

Question: Are there gentle hand exercises for severe arthritis?

Short answer: Yes — gentle finger bends, thumb-to-fingertip touches, wrist circles and warm-water exercises. Keep sessions to 5 minutes, 3–4 times daily.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk